

Exercises & Homework Workbook

Cooking is a physical skill; reading about it is not enough. For each module, do the hands-on exercises first to build the motion, then complete the homework to apply it to a real dish. Check off each item and jot a quick note on what to fix next time. Repeat any drill that still feels clumsy before moving on.

How to log your work

- Date each attempt. Skills improve with reps, and the dates prove it.
- After each cook, write one thing that worked and one thing to change.
- Photograph plates; a visual journal is the start of a portfolio (Module 12).
- Use the interactive Recipe Card to capture any dish you want to make again.

MODULE 01

Kitchen Foundations: Safety, Sanitation & Setup**Hands-on exercises (build the motion)**

Done	Exercise / drill	Notes (what to fix next time)
☐	Personal & station hygiene; handwashing; the danger zone (40-140 deg F / 4-60 deg C)	
☐	Cross-contamination, color-coded boards, allergen awareness	
☐	FIFO, labeling, fridge/freezer organization and storage temps	
☐	Tool overview: knives, boards, pots, pans, thermometers, scales	
☐	Reading & scaling recipes; understanding mise en place	

Homework (apply it to a dish)

Done	Assignment	Date / result
☐	Deep-clean and reorganize your kitchen using FIFO; photograph before/after.	
☐	Print the Temperature & Doneness guide and post it inside a cabinet door.	
☐	Write your own one-page kitchen safety checklist and follow it for one week.	

Self-check: I can perform this module's core skills without a recipe. Yes ☐ Not yet ☐

MODULE 02

Knife Skills & Mise en Place

Hands-on exercises (build the motion)

Done	Exercise / drill	Notes (what to fix next time)
☐	Anatomy of a chef's knife; pinch grip & claw	
☐	The standard cuts and their dimensions	
☐	Onion, garlic, shallot, carrot, and herb breakdowns	
☐	Honing vs. sharpening; board setup; safety	
☐	Building mise en place: everything in its place before heat	

Homework (apply it to a dish)

Done	Assignment	Date / result
☐	The 5-pound onion drill: dice five onions, aiming for even pieces. Save for soups.	
☐	Film your grip and one dice; compare to a Pepin demo and note 3 fixes.	
☐	Prep a full mise en place for one dinner before turning on any burner.	

Self-check: I can perform this module's core skills without a recipe. Yes ☐ Not yet ☐

MODULE 03

Heat & Cooking Methods

Hands-on exercises (build the motion)

Done	Exercise / drill	Notes (what to fix next time)
☐	Conduction, convection, radiation; how heat moves	
☐	Maillard browning vs. caramelization; the role of fond	
☐	Saute & sear; pan temperature and oil smoke points	
☐	Roasting, braising, poaching, steaming, deep- and shallow-frying	
☐	Resting, carryover cooking, and reading doneness	

Homework (apply it to a dish)

Done	Assignment	Date / result
☐	Cook the same vegetable three ways (roast, saute, steam); taste side by side and journal.	
☐	Build and reduce a simple pan sauce from fond after searing.	
☐	Sear a protein to a target internal temperature using a thermometer.	

Self-check: I can perform this module's core skills without a recipe. Yes ☐ Not yet ☐

MODULE 04

Stocks, Soups & the Five Mother Sauces

Hands-on exercises (build the motion)

Done	Exercise / drill	Notes (what to fix next time)
☐	White & brown stock; the importance of skimming	
☐	Roux: white, blond, brown; thickening ratios	
☐	Bechamel, Veloute, Espagnole, Tomato, Hollandaise + derivatives	
☐	Emulsions: temporary vs. stable; saving a broken sauce	
☐	Soup architecture and seasoning to taste	

Homework (apply it to a dish)

Done	Assignment	Date / result
☐	Make one stock from scratch and reduce part of it to a glace.	
☐	Produce a bechamel and turn it into a mornay; note the ratio you used.	
☐	Make and rescue a deliberately 'broken' hollandaise.	

Self-check: I can perform this module's core skills without a recipe. Yes ☐ Not yet ☐

MODULE 05

Eggs, Dairy & Breakfast Mastery

Hands-on exercises (build the motion)

Done	Exercise / drill	Notes (what to fix next time)
☐	Egg structure; how proteins set with heat	
☐	The rolled French omelet vs. the diner omelet	
☐	Poaching technique; the vortex and fresh eggs	
☐	Custards, creme anglaise, and tempering	
☐	Crepes, pancakes, and griddle control	

Homework (apply it to a dish)

Done	Assignment	Date / result
☐	Make a rolled French omelet with no browning; repeat until clean.	
☐	Poach two eggs with set whites and runny yolks.	
☐	Make creme anglaise without scrambling it; strain and chill.	

Self-check: I can perform this module's core skills without a recipe. Yes ☐ Not yet ☐

MODULE 06

Vegetables, Grains & Legumes

Hands-on exercises (build the motion)

Done	Exercise / drill	Notes (what to fix next time)
☐	Blanching & shocking; seasoning water	
☐	Roasting for caramelization; glazing root vegetables	
☐	Rice methods (absorption, pilaf, risotto); grain ratios	
☐	Dried vs. canned legumes; soaking and salting	
☐	Purees, mashes, and vegetable sauces	

Homework (apply it to a dish)

Done	Assignment	Date / result
☐	Blanch and shock a green vegetable; compare to one boiled to death.	
☐	Cook a risotto, stirring for proper creaminess without cream.	
☐	Build a fully vegetarian dinner plate that you would pay for.	

Self-check: I can perform this module's core skills without a recipe. Yes ☐ Not yet ☐

MODULE 07

Proteins I: Poultry & Meat

Hands-on exercises (build the motion)

Done	Exercise / drill	Notes (what to fix next time)
☐	Whole-chicken fabrication; trussing	
☐	Roasting: high vs. moderate heat; carryover	
☐	Braising tough cuts; collagen to gelatin	
☐	Steak doneness and temperatures; the reverse sear	
☐	Resting, slicing against the grain, and jus	

Homework (apply it to a dish)

Done	Assignment	Date / result
☐	Break down a whole chicken; save the carcass for stock (Module 4).	
☐	Roast a chicken to 165 deg F in the breast and rest it; evaluate juiciness.	
☐	Braise a tough cut until fork-tender; reduce the braising liquid into sauce.	

Self-check: I can perform this module's core skills without a recipe. Yes ☐ Not yet ☐

MODULE 08

Proteins II: Fish & Seafood

Hands-on exercises (build the motion)

Done	Exercise / drill	Notes (what to fix next time)
☐	Buying & storing; signs of freshness	
☐	Crisp-skin pan searing; the press-and-wait	
☐	Poaching and steaming; court bouillon	
☐	Shellfish timing; carryover in seafood	
☐	Acid, salt, and finishing seafood	

Homework (apply it to a dish)

Done	Assignment	Date / result
☐	Pan-sear a skin-on fillet to crisp skin without tearing.	
☐	Steam mussels and build a quick pan broth to serve with bread.	
☐	Cook scallops with a proper sear and a barely-warm center.	

Self-check: I can perform this module's core skills without a recipe. Yes ☐ Not yet ☐

MODULE 09

Baking & Pastry Fundamentals

Hands-on exercises (build the motion)

Done	Exercise / drill	Notes (what to fix next time)
☐	Weighing & baker's percentage	
☐	Gluten development; kneading & rest	
☐	Lamination basics; pie & tart dough	
☐	Creaming, foaming, and the muffin method	
☐	Custards, ganache, and basic plated dessert	

Homework (apply it to a dish)

Done	Assignment	Date / result
☐	Bake a simple loaf by weight; log hydration and crumb.	
☐	Make an all-butter pie dough and blind-bake a shell.	
☐	Bake one cake by the creaming method and evaluate crumb.	

Self-check: I can perform this module's core skills without a recipe. Yes ☐ Not yet ☐

MODULE 10

Global Cuisines: French, Italian, Asian & Latin

Hands-on exercises (build the motion)

Done	Exercise / drill	Notes (what to fix next time)
☐	Italian: fresh pasta, ragu, emulsified sauces, risotto	
☐	Asian: stir-fry, steaming, rice, balance of salt/sweet/sour/umami	
☐	Latin: salsas, braises, beans, masa, marinades	
☐	French: bistro classics tying together earlier modules	
☐	Building a regional pantry and substitutions	

Homework (apply it to a dish)

Done	Assignment	Date / result
☐	Make fresh pasta by hand and sauce it with an emulsified butter or tomato sauce.	
☐	Cook a high-heat stir-fry with properly prepped mise en place.	
☐	Prepare one Latin braise plus a fresh salsa to accompany it.	

Self-check: I can perform this module's core skills without a recipe. Yes ☐ Not yet ☐

MODULE 11

Flavor, Seasoning & Menu Development

Hands-on exercises (build the motion)

Done	Exercise / drill	Notes (what to fix next time)
☐	Salt, Fat, Acid, Heat as a framework	
☐	Tasting and adjusting; the 'what does it need?' loop	
☐	Building spice blends and aromatic bases (mirepoix, sofrito, mirin)	
☐	Layering umami; finishing techniques	
☐	Menu writing, balance, and cost awareness	

Homework (apply it to a dish)

Done	Assignment	Date / result
☐	Take one bland dish and fix it using only salt, acid, fat, and heat; document each change.	
☐	Develop one original dish and write it as a formal recipe card (template provided).	
☐	Design a three-course menu with a shopping list and timeline.	

Self-check: I can perform this module's core skills without a recipe. Yes ☐ Not yet ☐

MODULE 12

The Professional Kitchen: Line, Plating & Career

Hands-on exercises (build the motion)

Done	Exercise / drill	Notes (what to fix next time)
☐	Mise en place at scale; the pass and expediting	
☐	Timing and 'firing' multiple dishes	
☐	Plating principles: negative space, height, sauce, garnish	
☐	Brigade system and station responsibilities	
☐	Careers: staging, culinary school vs. self-taught, building a portfolio	

Homework (apply it to a dish)

Done	Assignment	Date / result
☐	Cook a full three-course meal for guests, plated, all landing on time.	
☐	Photograph your three best plates and write a short tasting note for each.	
☐	Draft a 12-month plan: skills to drill, a target stage, and a portfolio outline.	

Self-check: I can perform this module's core skills without a recipe. Yes ☐ Not yet ☐

Capstone: Cook a Service

Your final assessment is to plan and cook a three-course meal for guests, with every dish plated and landing hot and on time. This pulls together mise en place, timing, technique, seasoning, and plating from the entire program.

Plan

- Write the menu and a full prep list (your mise en place).
- Build a backward timeline: what is fired when, so everything finishes together.
- Shop with a complete list; do as much prep ahead as quality allows.
- Cook, plate, and serve. Photograph each plate.
- Afterward, write one paragraph of honest self-critique per course.